obsolete. Now, with all we have accomplished here, you do this and throw in this roadblock and everything is out the window.

“There is no way we are going to give up research to find a defense weapon against nuclear missiles,” I said. It had been the Strategic Defense Initiative that had brought the Soviet Union to Geneva and Reykjavik. I wasn’t going to renege on my promises to the American people not to surrender the SDI.

We knew from intelligence information that the Soviets were secretly researching a missile defense system similar to the SDI; their technology was inferior to ours, but if we stopped work on the SDI and they continued work on their system, it meant we might wake up one morning to learn they alone had a defense against missiles. We couldn’t afford that. The SDI was an insurance policy to guarantee that the Soviets kept the commitments Gorbachev and I were making at Reykjavik. We had had enough experience with Soviet treaty violations to know that kind of insurance was necessary.

“If you are willing to abolish nuclear weapons,” I asked Gorbachev, “why are you so anxious to get rid of a defense against nuclear weapons? A nonnuclear defensive system like the SDI threatens no one.”

From the American vantage point, I said, it looked as if the Soviets didn’t want us to proceed with the SDI because the United States was ahead in this technology and they were trying to catch up.

To prove we had no intention of using the SDI offensively or as a shield during a first strike, I repeated my offer once again to open our laboratories and make the system available to all the world; I said it was to be a defense for the entire world that would make nuclear weapons obsolete and speed the day when nations had enough confidence in their security to give up such weapons.